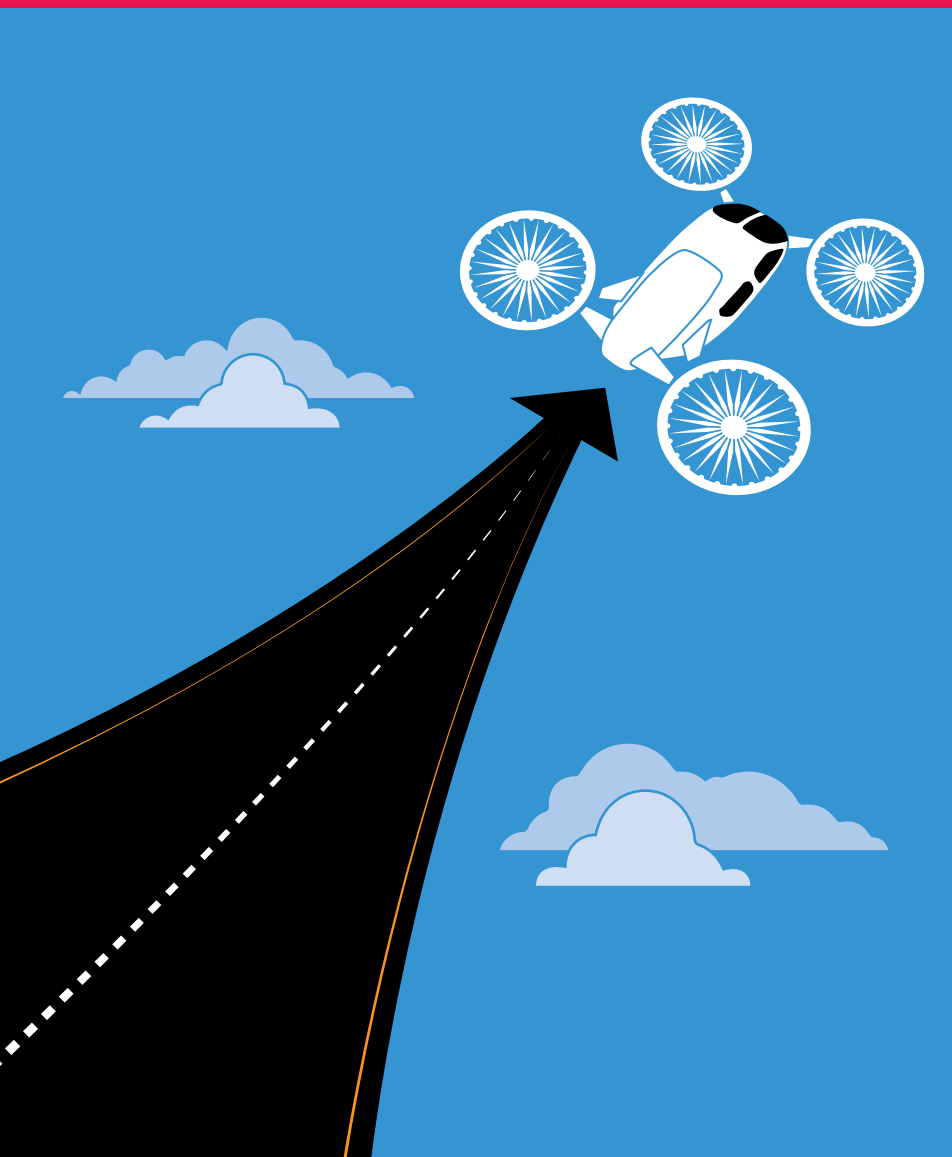


ILLUSTRATION BY **TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**

plans to establish such a network by 2047, after supporting the development leading to the full-scale demonstration mentioned above. What's more, the same infrastructure would hold all the way up to 1,200 kmph, which means going from Chennai to Bengaluru in 15 minutes! The cost to the passenger could be in the region of ₹1,500-2,500 per ticket.

While hyperloop can ensure mass rapid movement of people between specific urban hubs, a less

infrastructure-intensive approach that can spawn across is electric aerial mobility. The crux of electric aviation is its affordability.

Well before 2047, we can envision electric aircraft plying domestic routes primarily, at about half the present-day fares. More importantly, it will open up sectors that were hitherto unattended to, bringing up hundreds of new, small airports. The impact of this on the economy, starting from aircraft design and manufacturing, to their

operation, will be tremendous.

A micro aspect of electric aviation would be in the form of eVTOLs—electric vertical take-off and landing aircraft, which can take off and land vertically like a drone without the need for runways, and fly like a plane. These will transform urban mobility.

Further, these aircraft could more easily become autonomous, i.e., pilotless, even before driverless cars become commonplace on city streets. Going forward, voice-activated, or even better, conversational, and better still, thought-activated, flights are eminently possible.

Imagine a day when you could hail a ride on your phone app, get an eVTOL to your rooftop to take you to your city hyperloop station, and you get down the escalator from the vertiport there to get into the next hyperloop pod waiting to leave every two minutes, reach the next city in 15-20 minutes, get out and up the escalator to the vertiport to board the air taxi there to land on the rooftop of your actual destination in the host city, all under an hour!

The last but certainly not the least positive development to expect in the next 22 years is micro mobility in the last mile on the ground, enabled by electric bicycles, segways, etc. that are available on-demand.

Lastly, all the above rapid transit developments should lead to a massive decongestion of cities, making cities more walkable. Life would come a full circle as people would be able to include a healthy dose of walking as part of their daily mobility mix. **BT**

Views are personal